Core Financial System (FFMIA Compliance Initiative)

So here's where we are. We've got this thing hanging over us with FFMIA — basically the law says our financial management system has to substantially comply with a whole set of federal requirements, and right now nobody's totally confident we'd pass if someone came in and checked us against that standard tomorrow. So the real driver here isn't "let's build something cool," it's "we need a system that can actually stand up when auditors or the inspector general come knocking and ask us to prove our books are clean and under control."

The core of it is the general ledger — that's really the heart of everything, every other piece hangs off of it. We need to be able to classify and track transactions properly: by fund, by program, by organization, by project, by cost center, all that breakdown, because that's how budget and program managers actually slice and dice the data later. On top of that we need solid control over funds so we never end up obligating or spending more than what was actually appropriated to us, that's a hard line, not negotiable. Then there's the payment side — vendors, payees, getting money out the door correctly and being able to track and confirm that a payment actually went where it should. And on the flip side, we need to handle money coming in too, recording what's owed to the agency and following up when people don't pay.

Cost management is something we want in there as well, even if it's not glamorous — being able to actually measure what programs cost and what they're producing matters a lot for budget conversations down the line. And reporting ties the whole thing together: management needs timely numbers to make decisions, and we have to be able to produce the formal financial statements and reports that get sent up the chain, to oversight bodies and eventually made public.

Who's going to be touching this thing day to day: financial systems analysts, accountants, program managers, the people who actually run agency operations and need to pull numbers, and then auditors who'll come in periodically and poke at everything. So usability for non-technical finance folks matters, this can't be something only an IT person can operate.

On the technical side we do care about things like making sure it can handle the workload without falling over, that it talks properly with other systems we already have instead of becoming an island, that there's a real audit trail and security around who can touch what, and decent web access so people aren't stuck only using it from one terminal somewhere. That said, some of the fancier stuff — bells and whistles that are "nice to have" rather than something a law or regulation forces on us — that's not where we want to spend our first round of effort. If it's not mandatory and it's not clearly going to make somebody's job dramatically easier, it can wait, we shouldn't be chasing every optional feature in the first pass. The priority is getting the mandatory groundwork solid first.